



"I'm grateful that ICC has removed Steve BUCKNOR. The Indian board is quite happy about that."

SHARAD PAWAR, PRESIDENT, BCCI



"If Bucknor had been umpiring, public and COMMENTATORS would have pored over every decision he made."

MALCOLM SPEED, CEO, ICC

ner in which Tendulkar, known for his integrity and sense of fair play, was ignored. Tendulkar told Procter, "This was routine on-field banter between Harbhajan and Symonds. I did not hear any racial remark from any side." But Procter chose to believe the Australian version on the grounds that Tendulkar and the umpires were a little distance away and could not have caught the heated exchange.

Even the Indian team management's efforts to raise the issue of Brad Hogg using a derogatory word (bastard) to Kumble during the Sydney Test was brushed aside by Procter who said he would look into it later. Former Indian team coach Anshuman Gaekwad says Procter's racial bias is well known in cricketing circles. "He has always supported white skin, and pulled up players from India and Sri Lanka," he writes (*read The Racism Row*).

Faced with such blatantly one-sided decisions, Tendulkar called BCCI

President Sharad Pawar and apprised him of the situation. Pawar shot off letters to ICC boss Malcolm Speed, demanding Bucknor's removal from the Perth Test and clearing of Harbhajan's name of any racial slur and allowing him to continue playing in the series. The compromise, which allowed the off-spinner to play in the third Test, staved off a ballooning crisis but it has raised serious issues concerning the future of the game and the choice of umpires and match referees, which is entirely an ICC prerogative.

Indeed, the demand from the Indian tour management, backed by BCCI, that Harbhajan's name be cleared of any racial connotations remains unresolved. If ICC does not accede to the demands, India is unlikely to take part in the triangular series which has been planned. So far, India has only agreed to continue with the tour till January 16. "This is only an interim arrangement. BCCI is of the categorical view

that the matter will have to be finally resolved and the unfair allegation against an Indian player being set aside/withdrawn," said the statement issued by the board.

It is equally likely that the next Test match, or the one after, if the tour continues, will be played amid tension and hostility. Then there is the issue of how ICC resolves the current crisis. Speed says the removal of Bucknor and the appointment of Madugalle is a "one-off decision" but any team can cite this as a precedent if a similar situation arises at any point in future. As it is, umpiring standards the world over have become a contentious issue in most series, as has racism.

The Inzamam-ul-Haq controversy at the Oval where Australian umpire Darrel Hair was eventually dropped from the series and from ICC panel of umpires, is still fresh in cricketing minds. The current hostility may also cause some ugly scenes in Perth, from players or spectators and further strain relations between the two teams. The Australians are due to visit India later this year and if that does happen, they are certain to face a hostile reception from Indian crowds.

In private, ICC officials point out that both Cricket Australia (CA) and BCCI will ensure that the tour is not cancelled over any future development since there is too much at stake, more for BCCI, which needs CA and its players to counter Subhash Chandra's rebel league, Indian Cricket League and promote BCCI's own league. Any flashpoint that ends in a tour cancellation would mean disaster for both boards and players of the two countries.

Jingoistic commentators have talked of India's "vindication" but the truth is that the pressure of playing in Australia will only get worse as the tour progresses. Team India has already told BCCI that the slightest provocations, even the mildest of swear words, will be reported, which means that the Perth Test could be a battle royale. The wicket in Perth has been relaid and its bounce is gleefully being described as "trampoline". For now, ICC has applied a band aid solution but the crisis in world cricket is hardly over. In fact, it may have just begun. ■